INTRODUCTION · EXAM STRATEGY - ALL DOMAINS

# Databricks Certified Data Engineer Professional

A complete, original preparation course built against the current exam guide.

QUESTIONS 59 scored  TIME LIMIT 120 minutes  GUIDE VERSION 3 July 2026

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The Associate exam asks whether you can build a pipeline. This one asks whether you can **keep it running in production**.

# What changes at Professional level

THE ASSOCIATE ASKS

## Can you build it?

- Which tool reads this file format
- Write the transformation
- Schedule the job
- Grant the right privilege

THE PROFESSIONAL ASKS

## Can you run it?

- Why did this pipeline get slow
- Which of two working designs costs less
- What breaks when this stream restarts
- Prove the deletion actually happened

THE TIEBREAKER

If you can do a thing but cannot say why the alternative is worse, you are not ready for this paper.

# This certification is aimed at you if

- You already build and operate pipelines on Databricks, and want the credential to match.
- Databricks recommends **one year** of hands-on data engineering, plus the related training.
- There is **no formal prerequisite**. The Associate is recommended, not required.
- This is not an entry point. If Delta Lake and Unity Catalog are new to you, sit the Associate first.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Recommended training is the instructor-led Advanced Data Engineering With Databricks, plus four self-paced Academy courses.

# What exam day looks like

| | DETAIL |
|---|---|
| Questions | 59 scored, plus unmarked unscored items |
| Time limit | 120 minutes, about 2 minutes each |
| Format | Multiple choice, four options, one answer |
| Cost | 200 US dollars plus local tax |
| Delivery | Online proctored, or a test centre |
| Test aids | None at all, including API documentation |
| Validity | 2 years, recertify on the then-live exam |
| Pass mark | Not published by Databricks |

ON THE EXAM

No API documentation means syntax has to be recalled rather than looked up. That should change how you revise.

# Ten sections, and what each is worth

| SECTION | WEIGHT |
|---|---|
| 1. Developing code with Python and SQL | 22% |
| 2. Data ingestion and acquisition | 7% |
| 3. Transformation, cleansing and quality | 10% |
| 4. Data sharing and federation | 5% |
| 5. Monitoring and alerting | 10% |
| 6. Cost and performance optimization | 13% |
| 7. Data security and compliance | 10% |
| 8. Data governance | 7% |
| 9. Debugging and deploying | 10% |
| 10. Data modeling | 6% |

ON THE EXAM

Five sections carry 65% between them: developing code, cost and performance, monitoring, security, and debugging and deploying.

# What this exam actually dwells on

- **Streaming.** Triggers, checkpoints and state come up more than any other single topic.
- **Declarative pipelines** dominate section one. Streaming tables against materialized views is a recurring decision.
- **Delta internals.** The transaction log, statistics, time travel, and shallow against deep clone.
- **Data quality.** Expectations and quarantining bad records, far more than the weights alone suggest.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Streaming is not a section of its own. It is spread across sections one, two, three and six, which is exactly why it gets under-prepared.

# Original content, and why that matters

- **Every scenario here is original**, written from Databricks documentation and the current exam guide.
- A bank of **339 practice questions** was analysed to find which decisions the exam tests, and how often.
- **No question from that bank appears in this course.** Recycled dumps train recognition, not reasoning.
- Wrong options are explained too. That is what transfers to a question you have never seen.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Of those 339 questions, only 100 carried an answer and only 42 an explanation. That gap is a large part of why this course exists.

# What you may have learned it as

| YOU MAY KNOW IT AS | WHAT THE EXAM CALLS IT NOW |
|---|---|
| Delta Live Tables, or DLT | Lakeflow Spark Declarative Pipelines |
| Workflows | Lakeflow Jobs |
| Repos | Git folders |
| Databricks Asset Bundles | Declarative Automation Bundles, still DABs |
| APPLY CHANGES | AUTO CDC, with identical syntax |

ON THE EXAM

The July 2026 guide uses every name on the right, and prints the old one beside it in brackets. This course does the same.

# Where the guide has not caught up

- **Predictive optimization** runs OPTIMIZE, VACUUM and ANALYZE for you on Unity Catalog managed tables.
- On by default for accounts created after **November 2024**. The exam guide never mentions it.
- So an answer that schedules OPTIMIZE weekly is often the **worse** one now. Older banks are full of those.
- Bundles also stopped using Terraform by default. The direct deployment engine is now generally available.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Where the guide and the live product disagree, this course teaches the examinable answer and then tells you what is actually true.

# The conventions used throughout

- An **amber bar** at the foot of a slide is the exam takeaway. If you note one thing down, note that.
- Teal marks something that is true, useful, and worth reaching for.
- Red marks an anti-pattern, or something that looks right and is not.
- The small label above each heading tells you which idea the slide belongs to.

> ON THE EXAM
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> The marker down the left edge of every slide shows which of the ten sections you are currently in.

# Worked scenarios, and the one rule

- Most modules end with **four worked scenarios**: a situation, a question, and four options.
- **Pause and commit to an answer** before the walkthrough. Say it aloud, or write it down.
- The walkthrough then takes every option in turn and says why it wins or why it loses.
- Watching without answering first feels productive and teaches almost nothing.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Being wrong and understanding why beats being right by accident. The wrong options are where most of the teaching is.

# How the course is ordered

01

## Build

Sections 1 to 3. Code, pipelines, ingestion, transformation and quality.

02

## Share and watch

Sections 4 and 5. Delta Sharing, federation, system tables and alerts.

03

## Tune

Section 6. Delta internals, clustering, and what compute costs.

04

## Secure

Sections 7 and 8. Masking, purging, and Unity Catalog permissions.

05

## Ship

Sections 9 and 10. Debugging, bundles, and data modelling.

ON THE EXAM

Two cross-cutting modules and three practice exams follow. The order is deliberate: you cannot tune what you have not built.

# How to actually study this

- Watch in order. Later modules lean on vocabulary the earlier ones set up.
- Then sit **practice exam one**, and mark it section by section rather than only overall.
- Rewatch **only** your weakest section. Then space exams two and three several days apart.
- Revising what you already know keeps the scores high and moves nothing.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Which section your misses cluster in matters more than the score itself. That is the number to act on.

Ten sections, and **nowhere to hide**. The smallest is still five per cent of your result.